

The Reform Imperative



More than three decades after India opened its doors to the world, dismantling the Licence Raj and embracing global trade and markets, the nation finds itself at another historic crossroads. Having joined the World Trade Organization ahead of China and steadily lowering barriers to trade and investment, India reaped enormous dividends—foreign capital surged in, exports flourished, and tax revenues grew, allowing the state to lift millions out of poverty.

Yet, the rules-based global trade order is fraying due to the global turbulence unleashed by US President Donald Trump. Multilateralism is giving way to a fragmented, uncertain system, the contours of which are unclear. Perhaps clarity will emerge in the post-Trump era.

For now, every nation is looking inward. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, while reaffirming India's ambition to become the world's third-largest economy, recently underscored this shift, calling for the spirit of *Swadeshi*. His is a reminder that in an unstable world, India must focus sharply on its own economic priorities.

This is a moment that is fraught with risk. Trump's tariffs may pinch India's growth in the short term. But there is also a rare opportunity, a 1991 redux of sorts. Every crisis, after all, also presents an opportunity. If those reforms were about survival, the reforms we must envision now should be aimed at a major transformation that ensures India grows to a \$30 trillion economy by 2047.

That is why this issue of *Business Today* is different. It is a manifesto of ideas, 100 of them. There's something compelling about this number. It represents a milestone, a sense of completeness, and a pause to imagine the future. So, as you turn these pages, you will encounter a curated set of reform ideas, some grand and ambitious, some surgical and targeted—all aimed at reshaping our economic growth trajectory.

Thirty trillion dollars of economic output isn't a fantasy. In the last two decades, India's share of the global economy has doubled. Poverty has plummeted. Digital platforms have revolutionised every aspect of daily life. The ambition to become a high-income economy by 2047 is audacious, but within reach. What is certain, though, is that a business-as-usual approach will not get us there.

Our team has spent weeks on this project, engaging economists, industry leaders, former policymakers, and think tanks. The work led by *Surabhi* has resulted in a list of 100 reforms. Some are obvious, others deliberately provocative. Some could be executed tomorrow, others will demand years of political backing. Together, they underscore one truth: the choices we make in the next 23 years will define India's next 100.

We do not want you to just read this issue. We want you to wrestle with it. Disagree. Add your voice. Push for what you believe should happen. Because India@100 cannot be achieved by just a hundred ideas. Countless more are needed, backed by national will and collective action. **BT**

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